On the evening of 15 September, Pollock's weary force finally marched into Kabul to find that almost the entire population, including Akbar Khan, had fled the city. That night they set up camp on the race course built on Macnaghten's orders three years earlier, and the following day Shah Fatteh Jang was restored to the Bala Hisar, but this time with the Union Jack flying from the flagpole.

Nott and his Kandahar army marched in two days later; and on 21 September news arrived that the 120 prisoners of war were approaching too.[nn] Pollock had sent one of his young officers, Sir Richmond Shakespear, ahead to find them, along with a troop of 700 Qizilbash cavalry. Unaware that they had already liberated themselves, to his surprise Shakespearmet them coming confidently down the road towards him, protected by an escort of their former jailers. Amid the cheers and the cries of 'we are saved', there was a single dissenting voice. 'Brigadier Shelton could not forget the honour due to his rank as the senior military man,' wrote Lady Sale, 'and was much offended at Sir Richmond not having called on him first, and reported his arrival in due form.'[80] Mackenzie was now so ill and foggily feverish that he was unable to lift himself off the ground and said only 'Ah!' when told he had just been rescued: 'When he saw Sir Richmond exchange turbans with Saleh Mohammad the only thought which passed through his mind was a lazy wonder "if Shakespear would be covered in vermin in the process".'[81]

The day before the hostages made it back to Kabul, the party was met by General Sale, who had headed north to greet them. 'It is impossible to express our feelings on Sale's approach,' wrote Lady Sale, who had not seen her husband for nearly a year. 'To my daughter and myself happiness so long delayed, as to be almost unexpected was actually painful, and accompanied by a choking sensation which could not obtain relief in tears.'[82] When the still feverish Mackenzie stumbled over and said, '"General, I congratulate you!" the gallant old man turned towards him and tried to answer, but his feelings were too strong; he made a hideous series of grimaces, dug his spurs into horse, and galloped off as fast as he could.'[83]

When the prisoners of war finally arrived in Kabul they were greeted with a twenty-one-gun salute, and the infantry lined up to cheer all the captives as they passed into the camp. 'They presented an extraordinary appearance,'